

Q I've never changed a diaper before! Where do I start?

Pick a warm, draft-free spot—babies can object to the feel of cold air on their skin—and lay your baby down on a wiped-clean diaper mat or a towel.

Changing your baby's diaper at floor level is safest for your baby, but it can be tough on your back. A purpose-made changing table is convenient and easier for you, but you need to keep an eye on your baby at all times. Have everything you need on hand: the quicker and more efficient the diaper change, the less likely it is that your baby will become distressed.

YOU WILL NEED

» **A clean diaper**, and diaper liner if you are using disposable diapers.

» **Cotton balls and warm water.** Baby wipes can be harsh on your baby's skin, so limit their use and avoid them for newborns.

» **Diaper disposal system**, for disposal

» **Diaper cream** (optional)

CHANGING YOUR BABY'S DIAPER

Remove the old diaper. If it's dirty, use the front of the diaper to wipe away feces. Fold the diaper in on itself, seal with the tabs, and dispose of it (or flush a disposable liner if using reusables). When removing a boy's diaper, hold it over his penis for a moment so you don't get sprayed by urine.



1 Clean the diaper area with wet cotton pads, a washcloth, or wipes. Wipe girls from front to back to stop bacteria from reaching the vagina. Carefully clean around a boy's testes and penis, and don't pull foreskin.



2 Once you've finished, let the air get to the diaper area for a few minutes since this can help to prevent, or soothe, sore diaper rash. If you want, you can apply a thin layer of diaper cream to the skin.



3 Gently lift up his legs by the ankles, then slip a clean diaper under his bottom, bringing the side tabs level with the waist. Check that a boy's penis is facing down before bringing up the front of the diaper.



4 Bring the diaper up between the legs, and secure with the side tabs. You should be able to fit a finger between the diaper and tummy. For a reusable, put a liner inside the diaper, and add an outer wrap if using.

Q How often should I change my baby's diaper? It's hard to tell when it's wet.

It goes without saying that you should change your baby's diaper each time he has a bowel movement. With today's super absorbent disposables, it can be hard to tell if a diaper is wet. To get an idea, pour four tablespoons of water into a dry diaper—this is what a soaked one feels like. You'll change your baby's diaper at least six times a day after the first week.

Q Do I always need to change a diaper after a night feeding?

Use common sense and judgment when it comes to nighttime diaper changes. Some parents worry that the extra disruption this causes will make a sleepy, satisfied, and ready-to-settle-down baby suddenly very awake. Check the diaper. If it feels fairly dry and your baby doesn't have uncomfortable diaper rash, it's probably okay to leave it on. You may prefer, though, to be on the safe side and change his diaper so that he doesn't wake again shortly afterward feeling wet and uncomfortable.

Q What's the best way to treat my baby's sore bottom?

While diaper rash is common, when your baby's bottom becomes red, take this as a cue to check that you are practicing good diaper hygiene.

Spending time in wet and dirty diapers irritates your baby's skin. Babies usually let you know when they're dirty—or you can smell it!—but they don't always complain when a diaper is wet. Keep an eye on the state of his diapers and change them frequently. Baby wipes can be irritating on your baby's delicate skin, so avoid these while your baby's bottom looks sore, and use just warm water and cotton pads for cleaning. Let your baby go diaper-free for a short while every day so that the air can get to his skin to speed up healing. Before putting a new diaper on, apply a thin layer of zinc oxide diaper cream to protect his skin. If you have reusable diapers, make sure they are rinsed thoroughly after washing so that all traces of detergent are removed.